

SEVANTHIBHAI
SHAH

60, DIAMOND MERCHANT
DIRECTOR, VENUS JEWELS
TURNOVER IN 1988 Rs 5 crore
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 1,400 crore



SHAILASH RAVAL

JEWEL CHIEF

role MODELS

People who achieve success by sticking to the rules.

turning POINT

The loss of a big export order in 1978 due to poor quality.

the good PAYMASTER

Even a peon in Venus Jewels earns over Rs 14,000 a month.

It is literally the jewel in the crown of Surat's diamond industry. The facility of Venus Jewels, a Rs 1,400-crore turnover company, stands out for its sheer modernity. The seven-storey, three-million-sq-ft state-of-the-art factory, housing 1,500 employees of Venus Jewels can easily be compared to the best in the world. And behind its shiny existence is the resilience of the creator, Sevanthibhai Shah, the man who has transformed diamond processing in India.

It was in 1978, when an Antwerp-based diamond trader asked him at a meeting of diamond processors in Mumbai why Indian processing units produced such poor quality gems. The trader also made some unsavoury comments on the poor working conditions in India. That year only, he had lost a big export order because his workers had done a bad job. His Gujarati pride badly hurt, Shah resolved to correct that impression. Returning to Surat, where he already had a diamond processing unit in partnership with his brothers, he pushed for pioneer-

ing changes. He doubled the wages of his processors and created a new, training-cum-incentive based wage structure. He improved their working conditions and imported sophisticated machinery to process large-sized diamonds. Today, the average salary of an employee at Venus is Rs 5 lakh a year, the highest in the Indian diamond industry. Even a peon gets over Rs 14,000 a month. The flip-side of this incentive scheme is that workers face salary cuts if they compromise on quality. That's why diamond centres across the globe regard Shah as one of the industry icons.

For Shah, son of a money-lender from Vadgam in north Gujarat's Banaskantha district it has been a long and successful journey. "Making money is part of business but I believe in living life for a cause," he says. Over the years, he has earned himself the reputation of a man who plays by the book and is scrupulous when it comes to following the law. So it comes as no surprise to hear him say: "I admire people who achieve success by sticking to the rules."

by Uday Mahurkar